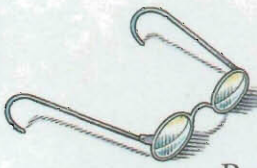


FRANKLIN, BENJAMIN

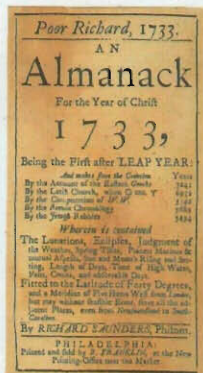


INVENTOR, PRINTER, PUBLISHER, writer, scientist, politician, diplomat, and an author of both the US Declaration of Independence and the US Constitution – there was nothing Benjamin Franklin did not turn his hand to. He

was born into a poor family, but had a fertile mind very receptive to new ideas. He invented items such as the lightning conductor and bifocal spectacles, but he is most respected for his contribution to the founding of the USA. He is sometimes known as the “wisest American”.

Printer

Franklin prospered as a printer. As publisher of the popular *Poor Richard's Almanac* between 1732–57, he introduced numerous common-sense sayings that have since become part of the American language. He also set up an academy that later became the University of Pennsylvania.



Scientist

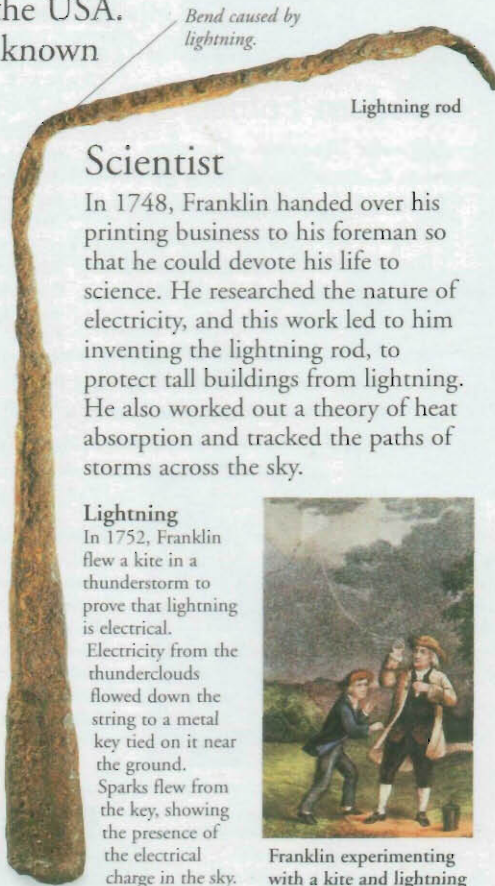
In 1748, Franklin handed over his printing business to his foreman so that he could devote his life to science. He researched the nature of electricity, and this work led to him inventing the lightning rod, to protect tall buildings from lightning. He also worked out a theory of heat absorption and tracked the paths of storms across the sky.

Lightning

In 1752, Franklin flew a kite in a thunderstorm to prove that lightning is electrical. Electricity from the thunderclouds flowed down the string to a metal key tied on it near the ground. Sparks flew from the key, showing the presence of the electrical charge in the sky.



Franklin experimenting with a kite and lightning



Early life

Benjamin Franklin was born in 1706 in the American port of Boston. He was the son of a candle and soap maker, and left school at 10 to help in his father's business. Later he worked for his half-brother James, printer and publisher of a newspaper to which Benjamin contributed. After disagreements with James, he left Boston in 1723 to work as a printer in Philadelphia.

Inventor

Franklin was a tireless inventor, using his scientific knowledge to devise a number of inventions that were designed to make human life safer and more comfortable. These ranged from bifocal spectacles – combining two lenses of different strength in one frame to correct both close and distant vision – to a musical glass “armonica”. Among his useful inventions were the lightning rod and an energy-saving stove still made today.

Stove

Among Franklin's many inventions was a practical stove that made use of the heat that would otherwise have escaped up the chimney. Stoves like this were installed in many American houses.



The armonica was played by rubbing the fingers gently on the edges of the glasses.

Armonica

In the early 1760s, Franklin built a musical instrument made up of a series of glass bowls, graduated in size and fitted one inside another. By rotating a spindle, the edges of the bowls passed through a trough of water. Contact with the musician's fingertips produced a penetrating sound. Composers such as Mozart and Beethoven wrote music for this strange device.



Constitution

In 1787, Franklin helped to write the new American constitution. Although his proposal for a single-chamber congress was rejected, he negotiated a compromise between the different authors which resulted in the constitution that survives today.

Statesman

During the American Revolution, Franklin was a member of the committee that wrote the Declaration of Independence, which he signed in 1776. Later that year, he sailed to France to win diplomatic recognition for the new nation. When the war ended, he was one of the main US negotiators in the peace talks.



Franklin (left) talks to the French king and queen (seated, right) and members of their court

BENJAMIN FRANKLIN

- 1706 Born in Boston, USA
- 1723 Begins work as a printer
- 1732–57 Publishes *Poor Richard's Almanac*
- 1752 Conducts famous experiment with lightning
- 1776 Helps to draft Declaration of Independence
- 1781 Chosen as one of the US negotiators with Britain
- 1787 Member of group which draws up US constitution
- 1790 Dies in Philadelphia

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